Chapter 2. Probability, Likelihood and Information Theory

Random variables, maximum likelihood, MAP estimation, Bayesian models; Entropy, KL divergence, mutual information, cross-entropy

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1 Events and Conditional Probability

Events are (measurable) subsets of a sample space Ω; the axioms (nonnegativity, $P(\Omega) = 1$, countable additivity) imply

$$P(\emptyset) = 0, \qquad P(E^c) = 1 - P(E), \qquad P(E \cup F) = P(E) + P(F) - P(E \cap F),$$

monotonicity $E \subseteq F \Rightarrow P(E) \le P(F)$, and continuity along increasing or decreasing sequences of events.

Definition 2.1: conditional probability, Bayes' rule, independence

For $P(E) > 0$, $P(F \mid E) = P(F \cap E)/P(E)$. For a partition $E_1, E_2, \dots$ of Ω,

$$P(F) = \sum_i P(F \mid E_i)P(E_i), \qquad P(E_i \mid F) = \frac{P(F \mid E_i)P(E_i)}{\sum_j P(F \mid E_j)P(E_j)}.$$

E, F are independent if $P(E \cap F) = P(E)P(F)$.

Example 2.2: why the prior matters

Let $P(D) = 0.01$, $P(+ \mid D) = 0.9$, $P(+ \mid D^c) = 0.1$. Then

$$P(D \mid +) = \frac{0.9(0.01)}{0.9(0.01) + 0.1(0.99)} \approx 0.0833.$$

A small prior keeps the posterior small. For two fair tosses, "first head" and "second head" (1/2 each, 1/4 jointly) are independent.

2 Random Variables and Distributions

Motivation. Data are samples from an unknown distribution and losses are expectations.

A random variable is a measurable $X : \Omega \to \mathbb{R}$ (e.g. heads in three tosses, $X(HHT) = 2$), with CDF $F_X(t) = P(X \le t)$.

- Discrete: probability mass $p(x) = P(X = x)$, $F_X(t) = \sum_{x \le t} p(x)$.
- Continuous: density $f \ge 0$ with $\int f = 1$, $P(a < X \le b) = \int_a^b f(u)\,du$. A density value is not a probability and may exceed one; $P(X = x) = 0$.

$$\mathbb{E}[g(X)] = \sum_x g(x)p(x) \text{ or } \int g(x)f(x)\,dx, \qquad \operatorname{Var}(X) = \mathbb{E}[X^2] - (\mathbb{E}X)^2.$$

Theorem 2.3: tools used throughout the course

(i) Linearity: $\mathbb{E}[aX + bY] = a\mathbb{E}X + b\mathbb{E}Y$ always.

(ii) Independence: $\mathbb{E}[XY] = \mathbb{E}X\,\mathbb{E}Y$; hence $\operatorname{Var}(X+Y) = \operatorname{Var}X + \operatorname{Var}Y$. Uncorrelatedness ($\operatorname{Cov} = 0$) suffices for the variance identity.

(iii) Tower property: $\mathbb{E}[\mathbb{E}[Z \mid X]] = \mathbb{E}Z$.

(iv) $\mathbb{E}[(Z - c)^2] = \operatorname{Var}Z + (\mathbb{E}Z - c)^2 \ge \operatorname{Var}Z$ for every constant c.

Proof. (iv): square $Z - c = (Z - \mathbb{E}Z) + (\mathbb{E}Z - c)$; the cross term has mean 0. The other items are standard. ■

3 Maximum Likelihood Estimation

Definition 2.4: likelihood and MLE

For iid data $x_1, \dots, x_n$ from $p(x \mid \theta)$,

$$L(\theta) = \prod_{i=1}^{n} p(x_i \mid \theta), \qquad \hat{\theta}_{\text{MLE}} = \arg\max_{\theta} \sum_{i=1}^{n} \log p(x_i \mid \theta).$$

Data fixed, θ varies; L is not a distribution over θ. The log keeps the maximizer.

Example 2.5: Bernoulli, including the boundary

$x_i \in \{0, 1\}$ with $P(x_i = 1) = \theta$; let $s = \sum x_i$, $f = n - s$. Then $\log L = s \log \theta + f \log(1 - \theta)$. For $0 < s < n$,

$$\frac{d}{d\theta} \log L = \frac{s}{\theta} - \frac{f}{1 - \theta} = 0 \iff \theta = \frac{s}{n}, \qquad \frac{d^2}{d\theta^2} \log L < 0.$$

If $s = 0$, $L = (1 - \theta)^n$ is decreasing and the maximizer is 0; if $s = n$ it is 1: both equal s/n, without the derivative argument. Eight heads in ten gives 0.8; two positive reviews of two gives the extreme 1.

Example 2.6: Gaussian

For $x_i \overset{\text{iid}}{\sim} N(\mu, \sigma^2)$, $\log L = -\frac{n}{2} \log(2\pi\sigma^2) - \frac{1}{2\sigma^2} \sum (x_i - \mu)^2$, giving $\hat{\mu} = \bar{x}$ and $\hat{\sigma}^2 = \frac{1}{n} \sum (x_i - \bar{x})^2$ (biased; the unbiased version divides by $n - 1$).

4 Bayesian Inference and MAP

Motivation. A prior tempers maximum likelihood on little data; the posterior mode (MAP) is likelihood plus a regularizer.

Definition 2.7: prior, posterior, evidence, MAP

With prior $p(\theta)$ and likelihood $p(D \mid \theta)$,

$$p(\theta \mid D) = \frac{p(D \mid \theta) p(\theta)}{p(D)}, \qquad p(D) = \int p(D \mid \theta) p(\theta) \, d\theta,$$

$$\hat{\theta}_{\text{MAP}} = \arg\max_{\theta} \{\log p(D \mid \theta) + \log p(\theta)\}.$$

The evidence is free of θ; MAP is the posterior mode, not mean.

4.1 Beta–Bernoulli conjugacy

Theorem 2.8: Beta prior

If $\theta \sim \mathrm{Beta}(a, b)$, i.e. $p(\theta) = \theta^{a-1}(1-\theta)^{b-1}/B(a,b)$ with $B(a,b) = \Gamma(a)\Gamma(b)/\Gamma(a+b)$, and s successes, f failures are observed, then

$$\theta \mid D \sim \mathrm{Beta}(a+s,\, b+f), \qquad \mathbb{E}[\theta \mid D] = \frac{a+s}{a+b+n}, \qquad \hat{\theta}_{\mathrm{MAP}} = \frac{a+s-1}{a+b+n-2}$$

(the mode formula needs both posterior parameters above one).

Proof. $p(\theta \mid D) \propto \theta^s(1-\theta)^f \cdot \theta^{a-1}(1-\theta)^{b-1} = \theta^{(a+s)-1}(1-\theta)^{(b+f)-1}$, which is the $\mathrm{Beta}(a+s, b+f)$ kernel. For $\mathrm{Beta}(\alpha,\beta)$, $\mathbb{E}\theta = B(\alpha+1,\beta)/B(\alpha,\beta) = \alpha/(\alpha+\beta)$ using $\Gamma(z+1) = z\Gamma(z)$. The mode solves $\frac{\alpha-1}{\theta} = \frac{\beta-1}{1-\theta}$, i.e. $\theta = \frac{\alpha-1}{\alpha+\beta-2}$. ∎

Under the uniform prior $\mathrm{Beta}(1,1)$ the posterior mean $(s+1)/(n+2)$ (Laplace's rule of succession) is the predictive $P(X_{\mathrm{new}} = 1 \mid D) = \int \theta\, p(\theta \mid D)\, d\theta$.

Example 2.9: the two sellers

Seller 1: 90 positive, 10 negative reviews; seller 2: 2 positive, 0 negative. Uniform priors give

$$\theta_1 \mid D_1 \sim \mathrm{Beta}(91, 11), \qquad \theta_2 \mid D_2 \sim \mathrm{Beta}(3, 1).$$

Predictive probability of a positive next review: $91/102 \approx 0.892$ versus $3/4$ (seller 1), whereas the MLE (0.9 vs. 1) prefers seller 2. Since $\mathrm{Beta}(3,1)$ has CDF t^3,

$$P(\theta_1 > \theta_2 \mid D) = \mathbb{E}[\theta_1^3] = \frac{91 \cdot 92 \cdot 93}{102 \cdot 103 \cdot 104} \approx 0.713.$$

5 MAP as Regularization

Motivation. A Gaussian prior turns MAP into ℓ_2-penalized likelihood, so regularization has a probabilistic meaning.

5.1 Gaussian mean with a Gaussian prior

Let $X_1, \ldots, X_n \overset{\text{iid}}{\sim} N(\theta, 1)$ and prior $\theta \sim N(0, \tau^2)$.

Theorem 2.10: MAP is ridge, and it shrinks

$$\hat{\theta}_{\mathrm{MAP}} = \arg\min_{\theta} \sum_{i=1}^{n} (X_i - \theta)^2 + \lambda\theta^2, \quad \lambda = \frac{1}{\tau^2}, \qquad \hat{\theta}_{\mathrm{MAP}} = a\bar{X}, \quad a = \frac{n}{n+\lambda} = \frac{n\tau^2}{n\tau^2+1}.$$

Proof. $-\log p(\theta \mid X) = \frac{1}{2}\sum(X_i - \theta)^2 + \frac{\theta^2}{2\tau^2} + \text{const}$; multiplying by 2 gives the ridge objective. Setting the derivative $-2\sum(X_i - \theta) + 2\lambda\theta$ to zero gives $(n+\lambda)\theta = n\bar{X}$. ∎

Remark 2.11: Laplace prior gives the lasso

With $p(\theta) \propto e^{-|\theta|/b}$ instead, $-\log$ posterior is $\frac{1}{2}\sum(X_i-\theta)^2 + \frac{1}{b}|\theta|$ and the MAP is the soft threshold $\operatorname{sign}(\bar{X})\max(|\bar{X}| - \frac{1}{nb}, 0)$ (Chapter 3).

6 Information and Entropy

Motivation. Entropy, the average surprise, is the baseline for cross-entropy and KL losses.

Information $h(x) = -\log p(x)$: larger for rare outcomes, additive over independent events.

Definition 2.12: entropy

For a discrete random variable with pmf p,

$$H(X) = -\sum_x p(x)\log p(x) = \mathbb{E}[-\log p(X)], \qquad 0\log 0 := 0.$$

Natural logs give nats; base 2 gives bits.

Theorem 2.13: range of entropy

If X takes at most K values, $0 \le H(X) \le \log K$. $H = 0$ iff X is deterministic; $H = \log K$ iff X is uniform.

Proof. $-p\log p \ge 0$ on $[0,1]$, with equality iff $p \in \{0,1\}$. By Jensen for the concave log, $H = \mathbb{E}\log\frac{1}{p(X)} \le \log\mathbb{E}\frac{1}{p(X)} = \log\sum_{x:p(x)>0} 1 \le \log K$, with equality iff $1/p(X)$ is constant on the support and the support has K points. ■

(Differential entropy of a density can be negative.)

Definition 2.14: joint and conditional entropy

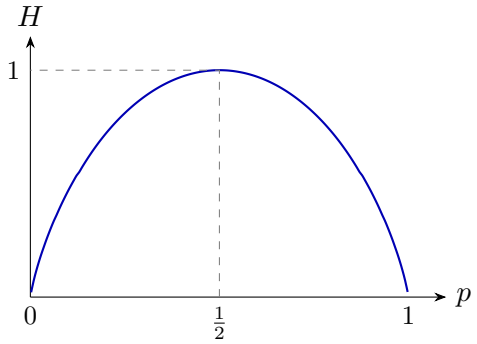
$$H(X,Y) = -\sum_{x,y} p(x,y)\log p(x,y),$$

$$H(Y \mid X) = -\sum_{x,y} p(x,y)\log p(y \mid x) = \sum_x p(x) H(Y \mid X = x).$$

Theorem 2.15: chain rule

$H(X,Y) = H(X) + H(Y \mid X)$.

Proof. Take $-\mathbb{E}$ of $\log p(X,Y) = \log p(X) + \log p(Y \mid X)$. ■



Bernoulli(p) entropy in bits, maximal at $p = \frac{1}{2}$.

7 Kullback–Leibler Divergence

Motivation. KL divergence is the expected extra log-loss from using q instead of p; it vanishes only at $q = p$.

Definition 2.16: KL divergence

$$D_{\mathrm{KL}}(p \,\|\, q) = \sum_x p(x) \log \frac{p(x)}{q(x)} = \mathbb{E}_p\Big[\log \frac{p(X)}{q(X)}\Big].$$

Terms with $p(x) = 0$ contribute 0; if $p(x) > 0 = q(x)$ for some x the divergence is $+\infty$.

Theorem 2.17: Gibbs' inequality

$D_{\mathrm{KL}}(p \,\|\, q) \geq 0$, with equality iff $p = q$.

Proof. Sum over $S = \{x : p(x) > 0\}$. By Jensen for the concave log,

$$-D_{\mathrm{KL}}(p \,\|\, q) = \sum_{x \in S} p(x) \log \frac{q(x)}{p(x)} \leq \log \sum_{x \in S} p(x) \frac{q(x)}{p(x)} = \log \sum_{x \in S} q(x) \leq \log 1 = 0.$$

Equality forces $q/p = c$ on S (Jensen) and $\sum_S q = 1$, so $c = 1$ and $q = p$; the converse is clear. ■

Example 2.18: KL is not symmetric

For Bernoulli parameters, $D(r \,\|\, s) = r \log \frac{r}{s} + (1-r) \log \frac{1-r}{1-s}$. With $r = 0.9$, $s = 0.5$: $D(r\|s) \approx 0.368$, $D(s\|r) \approx 0.511$ nats; KL is not a metric.

8 Mutual Information

Motivation. Mutual information measures how much X tells about Y; it is zero exactly under independence.

Definition 2.19: mutual information

$$I(X;Y) = D_{\mathrm{KL}}(p_{XY} \,\|\, p_X p_Y) = \sum_{x,y} p(x,y) \log \frac{p(x,y)}{p(x)p(y)}.$$

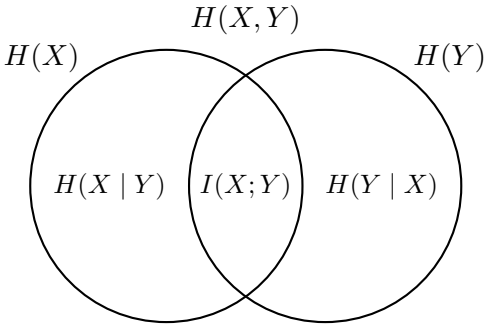
Theorem 2.20: identities

$$I(X;Y) = H(X) - H(X \mid Y) = H(Y) - H(Y \mid X) = H(X) + H(Y) - H(X,Y) \ \geq 0,$$

with $I = 0$ iff $X \perp Y$. Consequently $H(X \mid Y) \leq H(X)$ (conditioning reduces entropy).

Proof. $\log \frac{p(x,y)}{p(x)p(y)} = \log p(x \mid y) - \log p(x)$; taking $\mathbb{E}$ gives $H(X) - H(X \mid Y)$. The last form is the chain rule; nonnegativity and equality are Gibbs. ■

$H(X,Y) = H(X \mid Y) + I(X;Y) + H(Y \mid X)$. A fair bit with $Y = X$ has $I = 1$ bit; independent bits have $I = 0$.



The union of the disks is $H(X,Y)$; the overlap is $I(X;Y)$.

9 Cross-Entropy

Motivation. Cross-entropy is entropy plus KL, so minimizing it over the model minimizes KL.

Definition 2.21: cross-entropy

$H(p,q) = -\sum_x p(x) \log q(x) = \mathbb{E}_p[-\log q(X)]$.

Theorem 2.22: cross-entropy = entropy + KL

$H(p,q) = H(p) + D_{\mathrm{KL}}(p \,\|\, q)$. Hence for fixed p, $\arg\min_q H(p,q) = \arg\min_q D_{\mathrm{KL}}(p \,\|\, q) = p$.

Proof. $-\sum p \log q = -\sum p \log p + \sum p \log(p/q)$. The second statement uses Gibbs. ■

Remark 2.23: classification loss and soft labels

For one-hot $\mathbf{e}_y$, $H(\mathbf{e}_y, q) = D_{\mathrm{KL}}(\mathbf{e}_y \| q) = -\log q_y$, the classification loss. $H(p,q)$ is linear in p, so $H(\frac{1}{n}\sum_j \mathbf{e}_{y_j}, q) = \frac{1}{n}\sum_j (-\log q_{y_j})$: fitting the empirical label distribution by KL equals (up to $H(\hat{p})$) ordinary cross-entropy on each label.